

Certainly not by 13...hgx4 when 14 h5 gives White a crushing attack. The answer is by the sacrifice 13...Bxg4! 14 hxg4 Nxg4. A piece is a relatively small price to pay to ensure that the kingside stays closed whilst there is still every chance of Black developing an attack against the white king.

White should probably play 13 dxe5.

13...Na5 14 Ng3 bxc4 15 Be2 Rb4 16 Nf1 Bd7 17 Ne3 Qb8! 18 Rd2 Qb6 19 Nf5 Bxf5 20 exf5 Rb8! 21 Nd1

White's problem is that he is only attacking with one piece while Black is attacking with a whole armada. For example, after 21 fxg6 Rxb2 22 gxf7+ Kxf7 White doesn't even have a check.

21...Ra4!

With b2 heavily protected Black switches the attack to the a2-square.

22 Kb1 (Diagram 15)

Or 22 Nc3 Nb3+! 23 axb3 Ra1+ 24 Nb1 Qxb3 with a decisive attack.

22...Nb3!! 23 axb3

23 Rc2 Rxa2! 24 Kxa2 Qa5+ 25 Kb1 Qa1 mate is not an improvement.

23...Qxb3 24 fxg6

It's a case of too little too late.

24...Qa2+ 25 Kc1 Qa1+ 26 Kc2 Rab4 27 Bf1? Rxb2+ 28 Nxb2 Rxb2+ White resigns

Game 34

□ Michenka ■ Hagara

Trnec 1998

1 d4 Nf6 2 c4 g6 3 Nc3 Bg7 4 e4 d6 5 f3 0-0 6 Be3 Nc6 7 Qd2 a6 8 Nge2 Rb8 9 Nc1

OK, says White, your last couple of moves have scared me off castling queenside. I'm just going to castle kingside and try and show that those moves are now a waste of time.

9...e5!

With the white knight no longer protecting d4 Black seizes his chance to play ...e7-e5.

10 d5

10 Nb3 is also played from time to time when 10...cxd4 11 Nxd5 Nc5 gives Black a reasonable game.

10...Nd4 11 Nb3

11 Bxd4 exd4 12 Qxd4 would be risky even if it wasn't for the tactical shot 12...Nxe4!. Black now attacks the queen with his bishop and 13 Qxe4 loses to 13...Re8.

11...c5!

This sort of pawn sacrifice should become second nature to Panno players and it certainly leads to a sharper fight than 11...Nxb3 12

Starting Out: The King's Indian

axb3 c5, which is a solid but uninspiring way for Black to play.

12 dxc6

White must accept the offer as otherwise Black has cemented his knight in on d4 free of charge.

12...bxc6

Were you wondering why Black doesn't play 12...Nxb3 first? The point is that White doesn't recapture at once on b3 but throws in 13 c7! when 13...Nxd2 14 cxb8Q is not recommended and, after 13...Qxc7 14 axb3, White has kept the b-file closed and has a fine outpost on d5.

13 Nxd4 exd4 14 Bxd4 (Diagram 16)

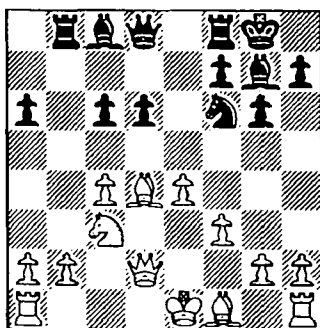


Diagram 16

Black has counterplay with ...d6-d5

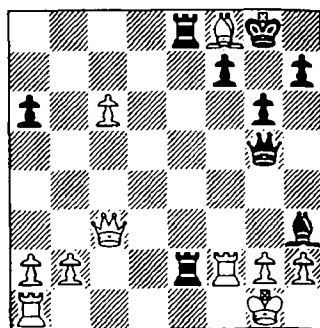


Diagram 17

An unexpected tactical shot

In return for his pawn Black has a lead in development and some interesting tactical ideas based on the fact that the white king is still two moves away from evacuating the centre (to castle queenside is almost unthinkable in such a position). It stands to reason that Black's plan is to blast open the centre whilst the white king is still in residence.

If you recall, in Game 32 it was pointed out that this position can also be reached with the inclusion of the moves h2-h4 and ...h7-h5. On a couple of occasions I shall be asking you to move your h-pawns up the board so we can compare the differences. They can be important.

14...Re8

Black decides he wants maximum activity before he plays ...d6-d5, as this is, of course, the move that is going to blast open the centre.

14...d5!? also comes into consideration, as does 14...Be6 followed by 15...d5. This last line is more effective with the pawns on h4 and h5.

15 Be2 d5 16 cxd5 Rb4?!

This leads to some fascinating tactical variations but it is probably better for Black to play 16...cxd5 17 e5 Nd7 18 f4 f6. White usually re-

turns the pawn now with 19 e6, leading to a roughly level game after either 19...Nf8 or 19...Rxe6.

17 Bc5

The move ...Rb4 created the nasty threat of 17...Nxe4 followed by ...Rxd4. White can prevent this with 17 e5 but then 17...Nxd5 18 Nxd5 Rxd4! 19 Qxd4 Bxe5 (or 19...Rxe5) gives Black excellent compensation for the exchange.



NOTE: In such positions the dark-squared bishop is usually worth at least a rook. With all the key pawns on light squares the dark squares in both camps are extremely vulnerable.

17...Nxe4! 18 fxe4

After 18 Nxe4 Rxb2 Black has a decisive attack.

18...Bxc3 19 Qxc3 Rbx4

This is the point of Black's combination. He now regains his sacrificed piece, but White is not too unhappy as he finally gets his king to safety.

20 0-0 Rxe2 21 dxc6! Qg5?!

With the pawns on h4 and h5 Black would have been able to play ...Qxh4 here. His attacking chances would then fully compensate for the advanced passed pawn White has on c6. With the pawns still at home Black should probably have settled for 21...Qc7 with reasonable chances to save the game.

22 Rf2! Bh3?

At first sight this looks like a terribly strong move as 23 g3 disastrously weakens the white king position and after 23 Qxh3?? Qxc5 White gets mated. However, White has a wonderful bishop sacrifice of his own.

23 Bf8!! (Diagram 17)

The sort of move that a computer program would see in a nanosecond but a human might not find after staring at the position for hours. The first point is that White now threatens Qg7 mate. Black has two ways to take the bishop but 23...Kxf8 loses to 24 Qh8+ and 25 Rxe2+ and 23...Rxf8 loses to 24 Rxe2. Black can stop the mate with 23...f6 but then 24 Qc4+ R2e6 25 c7 is winning for White. The only other possibility is to block the diagonal with a rook.

23...R2e5 24 Bd6 Re3 25 Bf4! Rxc3 26 Bxg5 Rc5 27 Bf4 Bc8 28 c7

The presence of opposite-coloured bishops offers Black some hope of achieving a draw but with a passed pawn so far advanced the game is always likely to be decided by a tactical blow. The remaining moves were:

28...g5 29 Bd6 Rc6 30 Rd1 f5 31 Rfd2 f4 32 h4 Bg4 33 Rf1 h6 34 hxg5 hxg5 35 Rd5 Kh7 36 Rxc3 Be2 37 Re1 Rxd6 38 Rxe2 Rd1+ 39 Kh2 Black resigns

Black Plays the Traditional 6...e5

1 d4 Nf6 2 c4 g6 3 Nc3 Bg7 4 e4 d6 5 f3 0-0 6 Be3 e5 (Diagram 18)

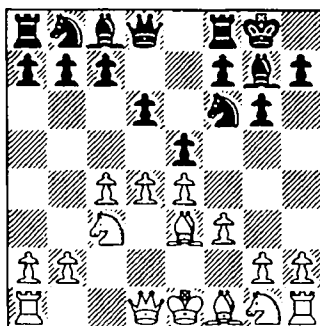


Diagram 18
The traditional 6...e5

The traditional approach appears to be mainly of historical interest at the moment. It has fallen some way behind the two previous variations in the popularity stakes. The problem is that after 6...e5 7 d5 White is well placed to meet the attack with ...f7-f5. Compare this position to the Classical where White often retreats his knight from f3 in order to be able to support his centre with f2-f3. In the Samisch the pawn is already there. 6...e5 was popular at the highest level until about 10 years ago with its main supporter being the then World Champion Garry Kasparov. Nothing really bad happened to 6...e5, it just became another victim of 6...c5's success. Black has always struggled to equalise in this line.

White has two main strategies after 6...e5. He can hold the centre with 7 Nge2, reserving the option to play d5 later, or adopt a totally different plan as we see in the main line of Game 35.

The alternative is to block the centre at once with 7 d5. Black will then usually look for counterplay on the kingside with a quick ...f7-f5, whilst White will concentrate more on the queenside. This is examined in Game 36.

Theoretical?

There are certain things worth knowing. If White is going to play the line with 11 c5 in Game 35 it will certainly pay to study this beforehand. After 7 d5 general principles take over but again, White should know something about Bronstein's famous queen sacrifice.

Statistics

At last White fights back. In the line with 7 Nge2 he has scored an excellent 60% in 1779 games. With 7 d5 he has notched up a very respectable 57% in nearly 3000 games.

Illustrative Games

Game 35

□ Istratescu ■ Akopian

European Championship, Ohrid 2001

1 d4 Nf6 2 c4 g6 3 Nc3 Bg7 4 e4 d6 5 f3 0-0 6 Be3 e5 7 Nge2 c6 8 Qd2 Nbd7 9 0-0-0

In Karpov-Kasparov, Linares 1993, White played the slightly cowardly 9 Rd1 and suffered one of the most humiliating defeats of his career. After 21 moves Karpov had seven pieces left (not including pawns) and they were all on the back rank!

9...a6 10 Kb1

White can also launch a kingside attack with any one of 10 g4, 10 h4 or 10 Bh6. Black will then retaliate with moves such as ...b7-b5 and ...Qa5. In practice Black has usually won the mating race.

10...b5 11 c5!? (Diagram 19)

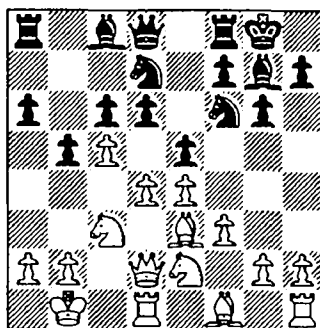


Diagram 19

White piles the pressure on

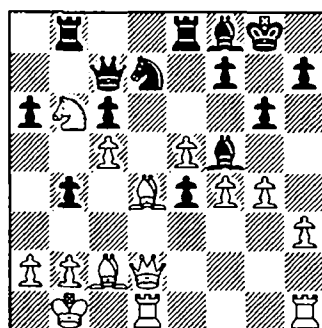


Diagram 20

Black's position is a nightmare

11 c5 has been known for some time but underestimated until recently. Its main supporter is the German Grandmaster Graf, formerly known as the Uzbek Grandmaster Nenashev. Confused?

11...b4

Black has two pawn captures. 11...dxc5 is obviously bad because of 12 dxe5, while 11...exd4 12 Nxd4 dxc5 13 Nxc6 is less clear but also